Choosing a CMMS: What Operators Wish They Had Asked

Insights from 21 Chapter members who replaced or implemented a maintenance management system

A computerised maintenance management system (CMMS) is the backbone of planned maintenance, SLA reporting and audit evidence. We asked 21 members what they would do differently. The answers were remarkably consistent: the software was rarely the problem; the data, the process and the people were.

1. Insights from the field

- Spend the first month on the asset register. A CMMS with 60% of assets tagged and 40% unknown delivers 60% of the value at best.
- Mobile first. If technicians cannot close a work order on the floor with a photograph, they will close it at the end of the week from memory.
- Integrations pay for themselves: BMS alarms creating tickets, helpdesk to CMMS, and CMMS to the finance system for spares.
- Insist on a sandbox with your own data before signing.
- Plan for reporting early. A dashboard that mirrors the SLA scorecard avoids a monthly spreadsheet exercise.

2. Evaluation questions

Area	Ask the vendor
Data	How do we bulk-import assets with hierarchy, locations and warranties? Who owns the data on exit?
Mobile	Does the app work offline? Can QR codes open the right asset and task?
Scheduling	Can we define PPM by meter, calendar and condition, and see load by technician?
Compliance	Does it hold statutory certificates with expiry reminders and permit-to-work records?
Cost	Is pricing per user, per asset or per site? What does an extra tenant cost?
Support	What is the local support team, response time and implementation plan?

3. Implementation roadmap

1. Weeks 1 to 4: asset survey, naming standard and criticality ratings.
2. Weeks 5 to 8: configure PPM schedules for the top 20% critical assets; train supervisors.
3. Weeks 9 to 12: go live on one building, run daily reviews, then roll out to the rest.
4. Month 4 onwards: add SLA reporting, spares control and cost tracking.

4. Warning signs

- Work orders closed in bulk at month end

- Ticket categories that nobody uses
- Technicians sharing one login
- A report nobody reads